



It's Dude Culture

Supporting Queer Students' Identities in STEM

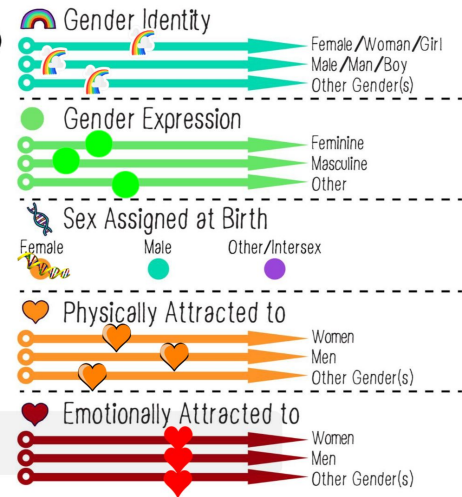
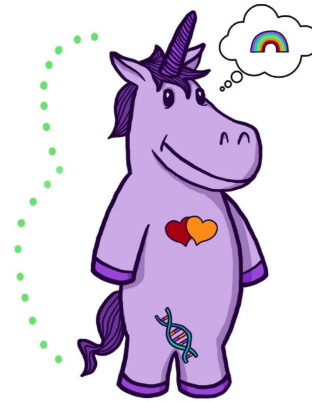
The Gender Unicorn

A way to think about gender and sexuality as a spectrum

The Gender Unicorn

Graphic by:
TSER
Trans Student Educational Resources

Drag each icon
to the correspond-
ing box to indicate your



To learn more, go to:
www.transstudent.org/gender

genially
Design by Landyn Pan and Anna Moore

Some Definitions

- Transgender - “an umbrella term inclusive of diverse communities of people. Transgender, or *trans*, describes an individual when their sex assigned at birth does not correspond to their gender expression or gender identity.
- Gender Identity - an individual’s sense of being male, female, both, or neither.
- Gender expression - describes a person’s physical appearance, clothing choice, and behaviors used to express aspects of gender identity or role.
- Cisgender - an individual’s gender identity and sex at birth align.
 - Note: The term *cisgender* should be used versus saying that an individual is *not* transgender.
- Sex assignment or natal sex - is determined at birth based on external genitalia, and sometimes genetics (often categorized as male, female, or intersex).
- Gender nonconforming - a person with a gender expression that is at odds with cultural gender expressions.
 - Both transgender and cisgender people can be gender nonconforming.

STEM Culture Today

- A pervasive culture of centering cisgender heterosexual men within STEM environments—referred to by students as dude or bro culture.
 - Some of the manifestations of dude or bro culture included: bonding over hypermasculinity and assumed heterosexuality, treatment of students with MloSG (minoritized identities of sexuality and/or gender) as if they are ***inferior or invisible, and sexualizing and objectifying others.***
- One student noted that “engineering climate is conservative and that she often chooses not to disclose her identities.”



Take 7

Small group discussion

- Have your group make a list of characteristics that you think define STEM culture in your school/place of work
- Categorize these characteristics as positive, negative, or neutral using a visual representation of your choice
- Be prepared to share your representation with the larger group

Queer Identities in STEM

- Prior research has shown the mere existence of a GSA club in a school is beneficial to the mental wellbeing of LGBTQ+ students and the specific focus of this article is the intersection of race and queer identities and how the formation of this type of collective identity creates both groups of students and individuals who are more comfortable in their identities.
- Within STEM, students' experiences of support was mixed and therefore not considered a consistent source of support and these students were turning to outside groups to support their identities within the STEM field.

Queer Identities in STEM (continued)

- Students struggled to build and maintain relationships with faculty because they said their identities would be ignored or ostracized by faculty.
- Another study observed that by providing queer campers an inclusive STEM environment, they more readily discussed their experiences at school vis-à-vis STEM identity's *competence*, *performance*, and *recognition*, as campers' STEM and queer identities developed positively.
- The common conceptualization of the university's role is to prepare students for the labor force, but evidence suggests that some queer students are learning to limit their expectations of their future careers, perhaps in light of previous and anticipated future discrimination.

Just Some Stats...

- Nearly 8 in 10 SMHPs (school mental health professionals) said that “bullying, name-calling, and/or harassment of students were serious problems in their schools.”
- A further 7 in 10 SMHPs “believed that students were bullied at least sometimes based upon their sexual orientation (73.9%) or gender expression (70.4%).”
- About 6 in 10 SMHPs reported **never or rarely** participating in LGBTQ-specific: in-service training (61.9%); conference workshops and panels (59.4%); or in other trainings and webinars (61.9%). This is in stark contrast to the over 80 percent of SMHPs who reported participating in similar type of professional development on bullying
- **But!** Only one third of SMHPs felt queer students would feel unsafe in their schools, close to half said that males with nonconforming gender expressions would feel unsafe



Students Say It Best

Why is this an issue?

A quote from one of the students, Devin, succinctly shows why this is problematic, “society teaches us to consider people with all of these binaries and all of these boxes that we put people in. Those limit the kind[s] of products that we can design...People really like to act like engineering is so objective, and it’s not, because nothing is, but people acting like it’s more objective, they’re actually being worse. It’s reconfirming all of those biases because they don’t ever question them. (Interview 1)” (p. 883).



Take 15

I believe

- Having talked about the issues that queer students face in STEM, work with your group to craft *at least* four “I believe” statements surrounding ways you can commit to create a more inclusive classroom
- Here is an [example](#) I created surrounding a trauma-informed classroom

It's all f-ed up. Burn it all down.

- Support (or start!) your school's GSA.
- Mentor students and encourage healthy peer to peer relationships.
- Consider using universal design when designing curricula to ensure that all identities and perspectives are represented and that a feeling of belonging is created for all students.
- STEM teachers need not affix themselves or their classes to just teaching content. One can still teach about culturally responsive topics (e.g., pronouns, identity beads, masks we wear) while teaching STEM concepts without having to sacrifice one or the other.

No, seriously. What do you do?

- Meaningful change will only happen “when all campus leaders—across academic affairs, diversity, student affairs, and other portfolios—begin to identify, educate, and devote resources to deep-rooted change” (p. 349).

NO SUCH THING AS THE INNOCENT BYSTANDER

Silence rides shotgun
wherever hate goes.